government too. Police officers sometimes intimidate suspects, fake evidence or beat up protestors. Soldiers haze new recruits or commit war crimes. Teachers and social workers abuse their power. (Even journalists can be crooked, deceitful or brutal.) Intelligence officers make mistakes too. It is true that the powers that the agencies enjoy mean that they must be particularly vigilant against abuse. But the really striking thing about the revelations to date (which are presumably cherry-picked to portray the NSA and its allies in the worst possible light) is the conscientious, tame and bureaucratic approach they reveal. It is true that the FISA court turned down few requests from the NSA. But this does not prove that the court is toothless. It reflects the fact that the NSA itself vets its own requests to weed out those that are unlikely to gain approval.

The recklessness, damage, narcissism, and self-righteousness of the Snowden camp do not invalidate all their aims. A debate on the collection and warehousing of meta-data was overdue. Collected and scrutinised, meta-data can breach privacy: if you know who called a suicide prevention helpline, or an HIV testing service, or a phone-sex line, and from where and when, the content of the calls matter less than the circumstances. These collections of meta-data, it should be noted, are not only vulnerable to abuse by nosy spooks: they are available in colossal amounts to private sector internet companies, some of whom may protect them only lightly and use them with far greater freedom than a bureaucrat.

More importantly in my view, the Obama administration has treated whistleblowers with scandalous harshness, especially those from inside the intelligence community. The hardest point for critics of Snowden is to explain what he should have done with his worries had he chosen to stay within the system. Genuine whistleblowers such as Thomas Drake, a senior NSA analyst, who believed (rightly or wrongly) that they were exposing abuses within the agency, were hounded and